

ANI



STUMPED Himachal CM Sukhu and defeated RS candidate Abhishek Singhvi talk to the press in Shimla, Jan. 27; (inset) Vikramaditya Singh

The rebels later blamed Sukhu's governance as the prime reason for them turning mutinous. An embarrassed Sukhu, for whom this was the first political test, initially offered to resign, but later dug his heels in. The party high command, not keen to deepen the sense of instability, also asked him to hang on. The drama surrounding Vikramaditya's resignation and its retraction, though, is unlikely to go away. It is an odd complication because his mother is both state unit chief and the party's only Lok Sabha member from the hill state. Pratibha Singh says her camp had "informed the high command that things were not going well a year back, but they did nothing".

Her group had earlier disapproved of the AICC decision to turn down the Ram Janmabhoomi Trust's invitation for the Ram temple Pran Pratishtha ceremony in Ayodhya on January 22. Himachal is a state where Hindutva symbolism always tends to get traction. In short, both realpolitik and ideology seem to converge in an ominous way for the Congress. The six MLAs who cross-voted have brought down the effective strength of the House to 62, so the Sukhu dispensation is hanging on with a tenuous strength of 34 seats for the moment. But one landslide in the hills can always bring on more, once the soil is loose. An en bloc desertion has been thwarted only for the want of a handful more legislators.

The BJP, meanwhile, has got exactly what the doctor ordered just before the general election. While rejuvenating the local cadre, it has lent more buoyancy to the larger narrative of a super-confident ruling party gliding towards a near-inevitable Lok Sabha victory—that perceptional gain will stands even if the Himachal government survives this blitz. The Rajya Sabha seat is a bonus, like the additional eighth one it eked out in Uttar Pradesh after forcing a poll with the nomination of another turncoat, Sanjay Seth.

If Seth was once close to the late Samajwadi Party supremo Mulayam Singh Yadav, Himachal's surprise winner Mahajan is a former Virbhadra aide and had formed one of the axes of factional power within the state Congress, as its working president, after the popular ex-CM's 2021 demise. He had joined the BJP in September 2022, just a couple of months before the assembly polls. The Congress win then had denied him immediate gratification; the return on investment has come now.

As much as the plain idea of a defeat, it's the spectacle of former loyalists crossing over to the BJP that will leave the Opposition dispirited. This is part and parcel of the BJP strategy: it actively works to demoralise its rivals before any big battle. This includes poaching strong local figures and the footsoldiers and voter base that comes along as part of the package deal. The BJP's digital war rooms, thus, have developed datasets that capture the strengths and weaknesses of not only their own men, but also that of opponents. That's why its aggression, such as that witnessed during these Rajya Sabha polls, actually works when the time comes. It's always deployed so as to serve more than one function.

For instance, in UP, it had already inducted the BSP's Ambedkar Nagar MP Ritesh Pandey. That made it easier to coax his father, the SP's Jalalpur MLA Rakesh Pandey, to cross-vote; also, Goshainganj MLA Abhay Singh. Both are among the five assembly seats within the Ambedkar Nagar LS constituency that the BJP had lost during the 2021 polls. All in all, it adds up to a picture of an inexorable tectonic shift. ■